to the reading in jail of such tracts as '*Ten Days That Shook the World* by Reed; *What Never Happened* by Ropshin; *Mother* by Maxim Gorky; *Career of a Nihilist* by Stepnik; *Nihilists* by Oscar Wilde; etc.'. Moreover, 'besides, Kropotkin's *Memoirs* and Michael Bakunin's *God and the State* had great influence on Bhagat Singh'.[7]

How did Bhagat Singh get his hands on such books? The answer seems to a large extent to be the Dwarka Das Library, founded by Lala Lajpat Rai, as the sister institution of the National College. M.M. Juneja describes it as 'promoting the noble cause of freedom, especially the Revolutionary Movement', because it contained 'a rich repository of books for radical-minded young men in Lahore' where 'its reading room was always crowded with students'. The library was fortunate in having been gifted with the services of 'its librarian, Raja Ram Shastri, just 21-years old then, who took over the charge of the Library in 1926'.[8] Yashpal, who was also closely associated with Bhagat Singh, wrote in 1951 that Raja Ram Shastri was 'a well known socialist of Kanpur' and that 'Shastriji often informed us about those who used to take a keen interest in revolutionary literature'.[9] When much later, Raja Ram Shastri published his own memoirs in 1981, aptly titled *Amar Shahidon Ke Sansmaran*, he confirmed how when he first arrived at the Dwarka Das Library 'it then contained all the books of Lala Lajpat Rai's personal library, which was a huge collection of world literature', but that 'I started collecting books, especially on Socialism, from different book-sellers of Lahore' including one in Anarkali Bazaar which 'was expert in smuggling the banned books from England'. Thereafter, 'since the library was visited by a large number of young readers, I always tried to supply them Socialist literature' and when Bhagat Singh 'started visiting my residence, . . . I got him enrolled as a regular member of the Library'. He continues, 'One day I saw him with a book, First War of Indian Independence by Veer Damodar Savarkar. It was a proscribed book.' Even Raja Ram Shastri did 'not know how it was procured by him' but it was clear to him that 'he was greatly impressed by him'.

Bhagat Singh went onto get Veer Savarkar's book published secretly in two volumes 'each volume costing 8 annas' and 'its marketing, which was